Reinforcement Learning

From Fundamentals to Advanced Policy Methods

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Universidad Distrital Francisco José de Caldas

2026-III





Outline

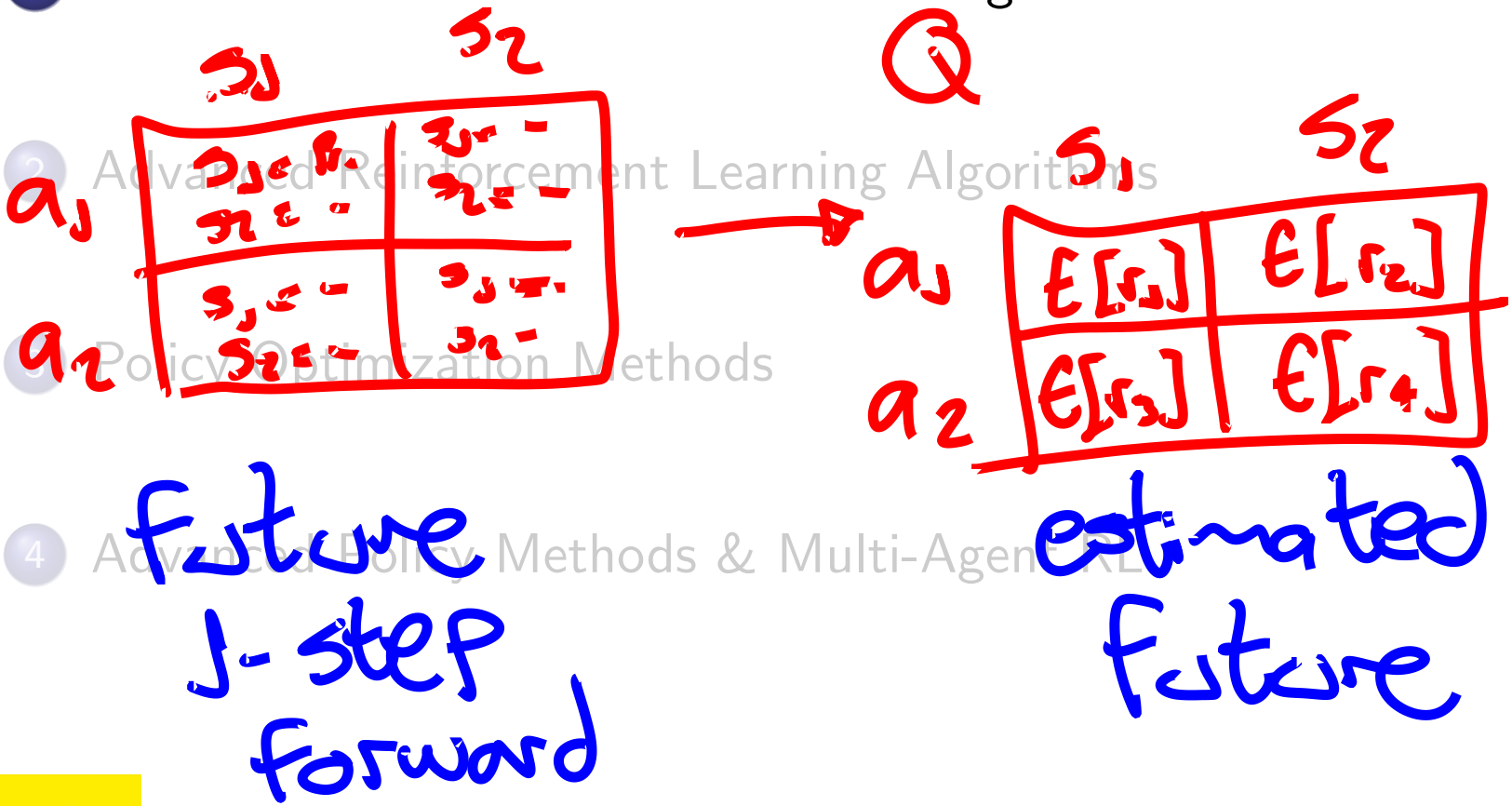
1. Introduction to Reinforcement Learning Fundamentals
2. Advanced Reinforcement Learning Algorithms
3. Policy Optimization Methods
4. Advanced Policy Methods & Multi-Agent RL



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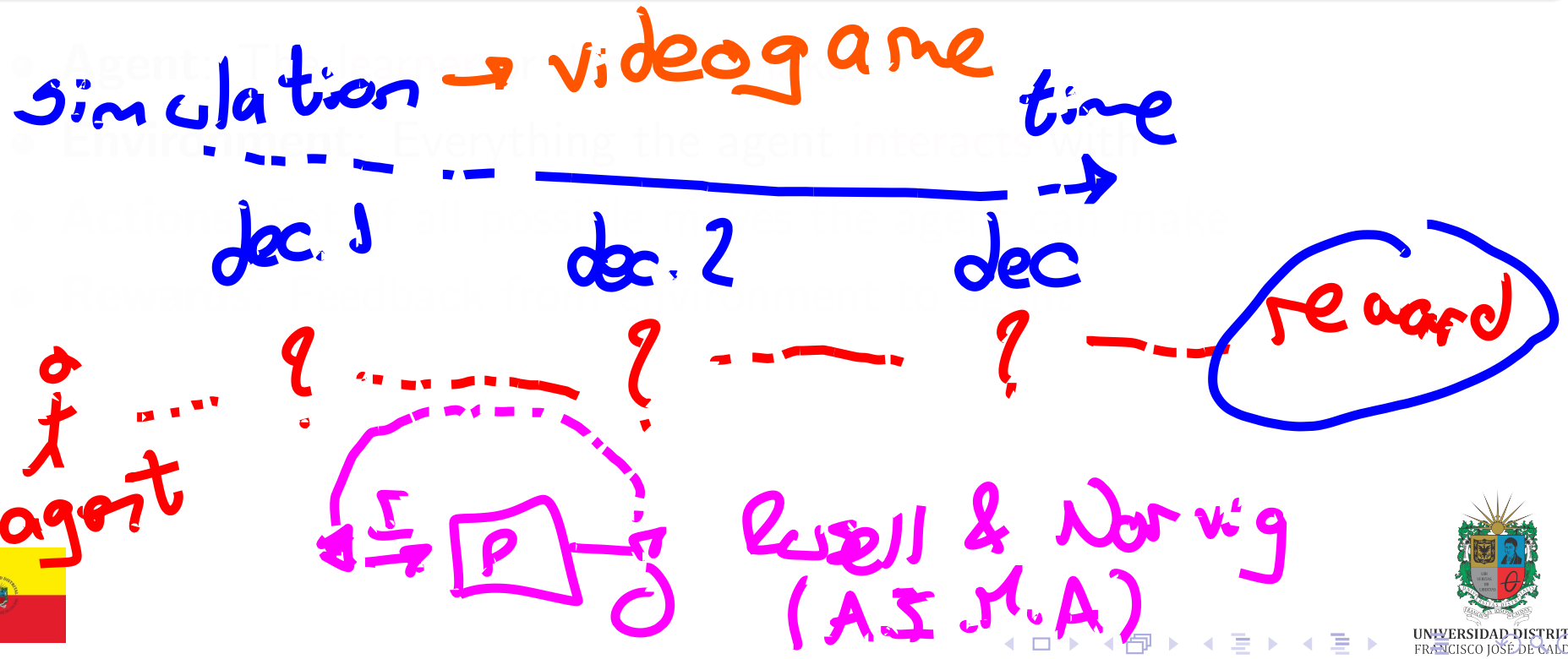
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What is Reinforcement Learning?

Reinforcement Learning

- **Reinforcement Learning** is a computational approach to learning whereby an agent tries to maximize the notion of cumulative reward.
- The agent learns to achieve a goal in an uncertain, potentially complex environment.

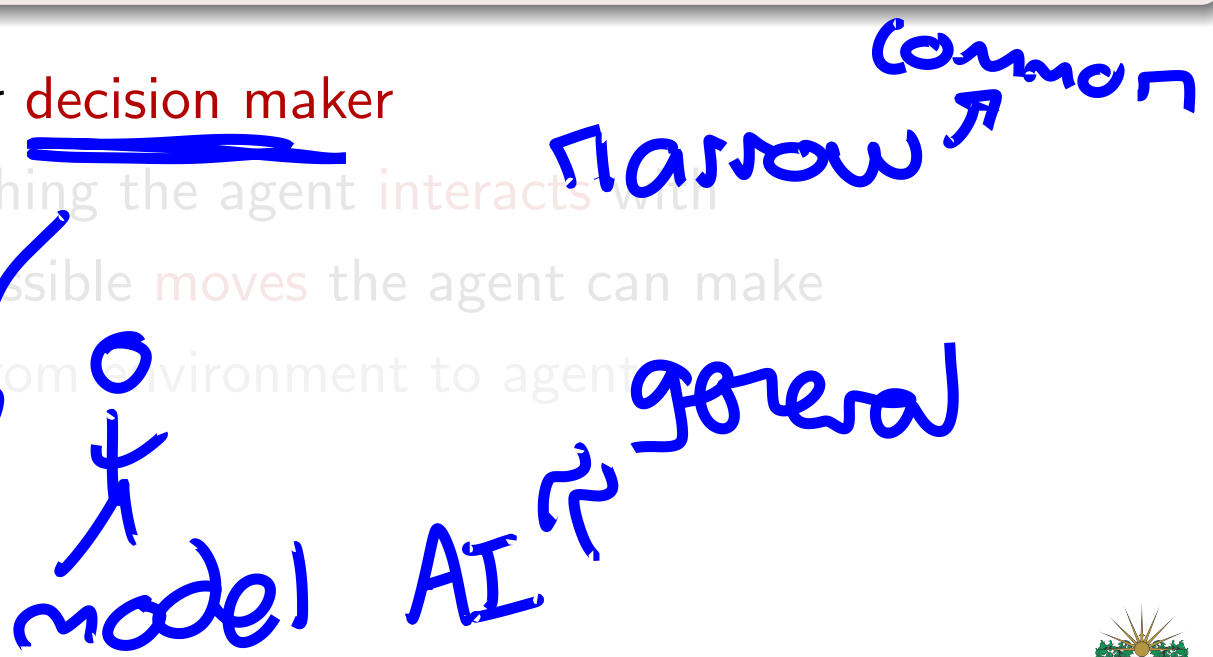


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- **Environment**: Everything the agent interacts with
- **Actions**: Set of all possible moves the agent can make
- **Rewards**: Feedback from environment to agent







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world stages

computational simulation



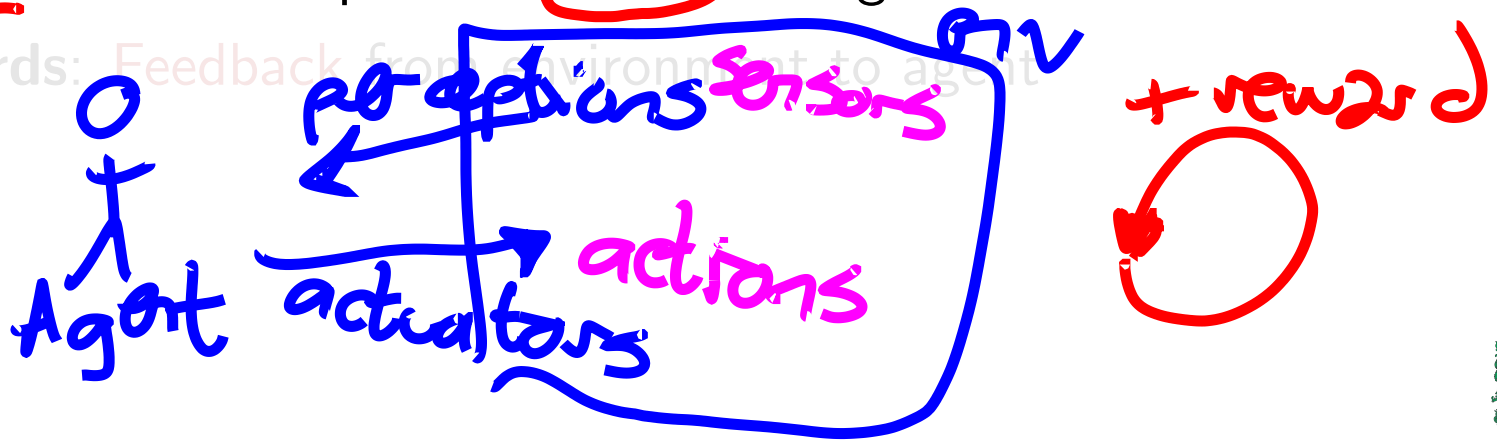


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RL vs. Other Learning Paradigms

Supervised Learning:

- Uses labeled data
- Direct feedback
- Static datasets

Unsupervised Learning:

- No labels
- Pattern discovery
- Structure finding



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Supervised Learning:

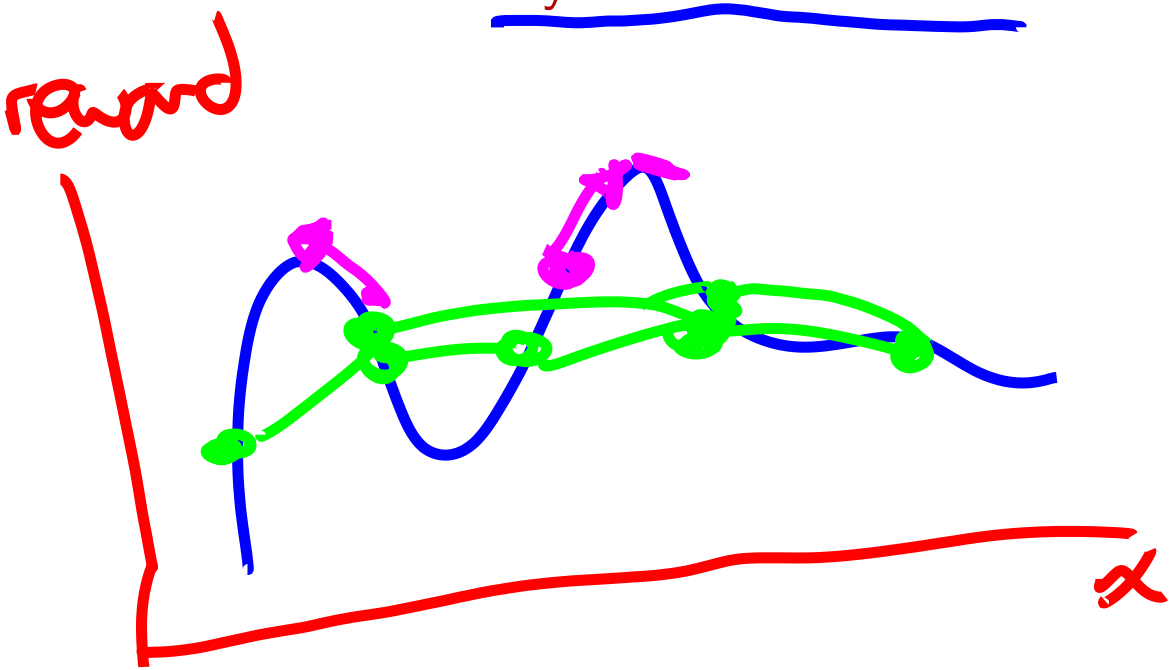
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Reinforcement Learning:

- Trial-and-error learning
- Delayed rewards
- Sequential decision making
- Exploration vs. exploitation
- Dynamic environments



Markov Decision Processes (MDPs)

An MDP is defined by the tuple (S, A, P, R, γ):

- **S**: Set of states
- **A**: Set of actions
- **P**: Transition probabilities $P(s'|s, a)$
- **R**: Reward function $R(s, a, s')$
- γ: Discount factor $[0, 1]$

Markov Property

The future is independent of the past given the present state.

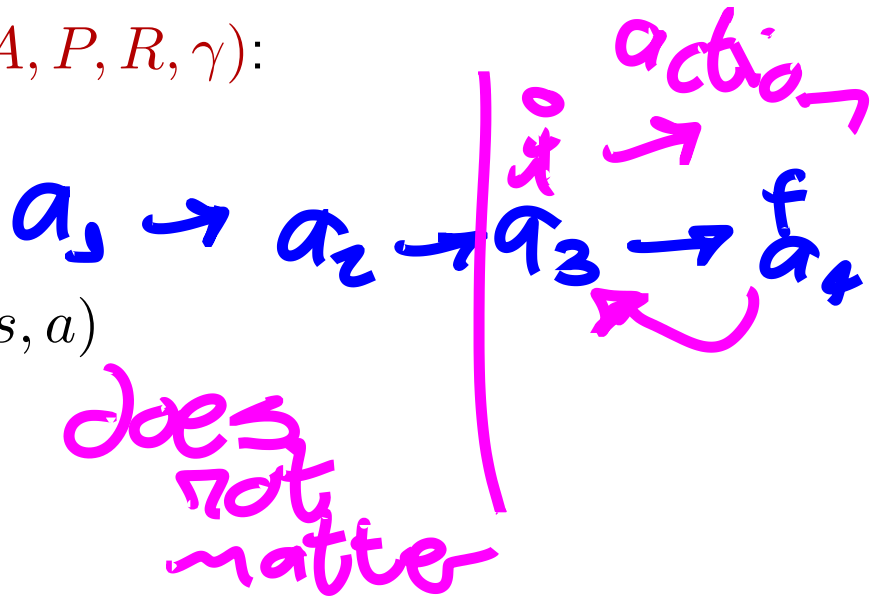
$$P(s_{t+1}|s_t, a_t, s_{t-1}, a_{t-1}, \dots) = P(s_{t+1}|s_t, a_t)$$



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Agent-Environment Interaction

The RL Loop:

1. Agent observes current state s_t
2. Agent selects action a_t based on policy $\pi(a|s)$
3. Environment transitions to new state s_{t+1}
4. Environment gives reward r_{t+1}
5. Agent updates its knowledge
6. Repeat...





Value Functions and Policies

Policy

A **policy** $\pi(a|s)$ is a mapping from states to probability distributions over actions.

Value Functions

- **State Value:** $V^\pi(s) = E[G_t|s_t = s]$
- **Action Value (Q-function):** $Q^\pi(s,a) = E[G_t|s_t = s, a_t = a]$

Where $G_t = \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \gamma^k r_{t+k+1}$ is the return.



Value Functions and Policies

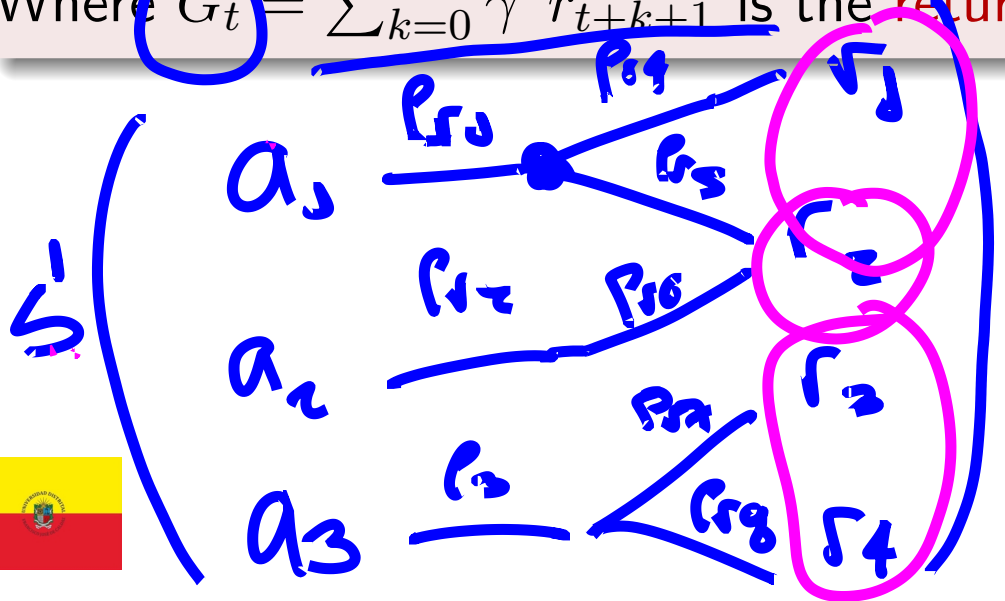
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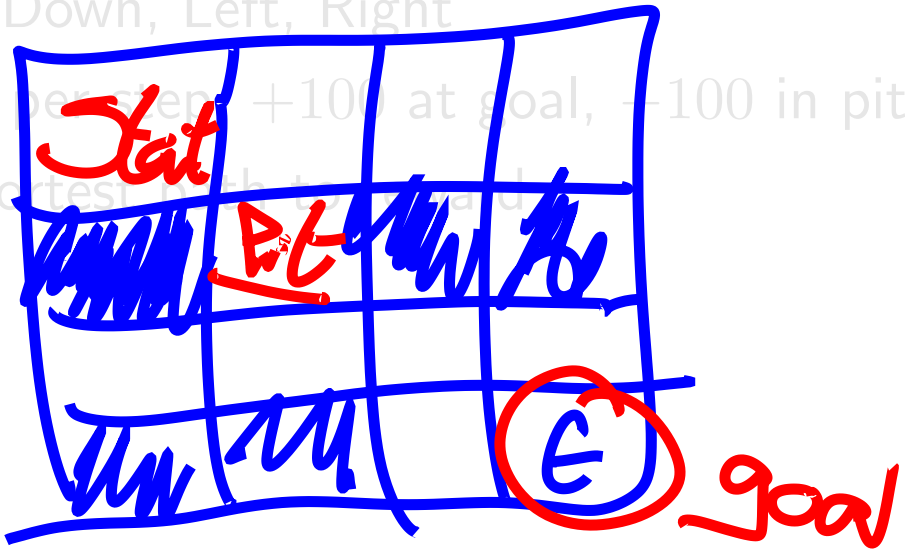
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Practical Example: Grid World Navigation

- **Environment**: 4×4 grid with walls and goal
- **States**: Agent's position (x, y)
- **Actions**: Up, Down, Left, Right
- **Rewards**: -1 per step, $+10$ at goal, -100 in pit
- **Goal**: Find shortest path to goal







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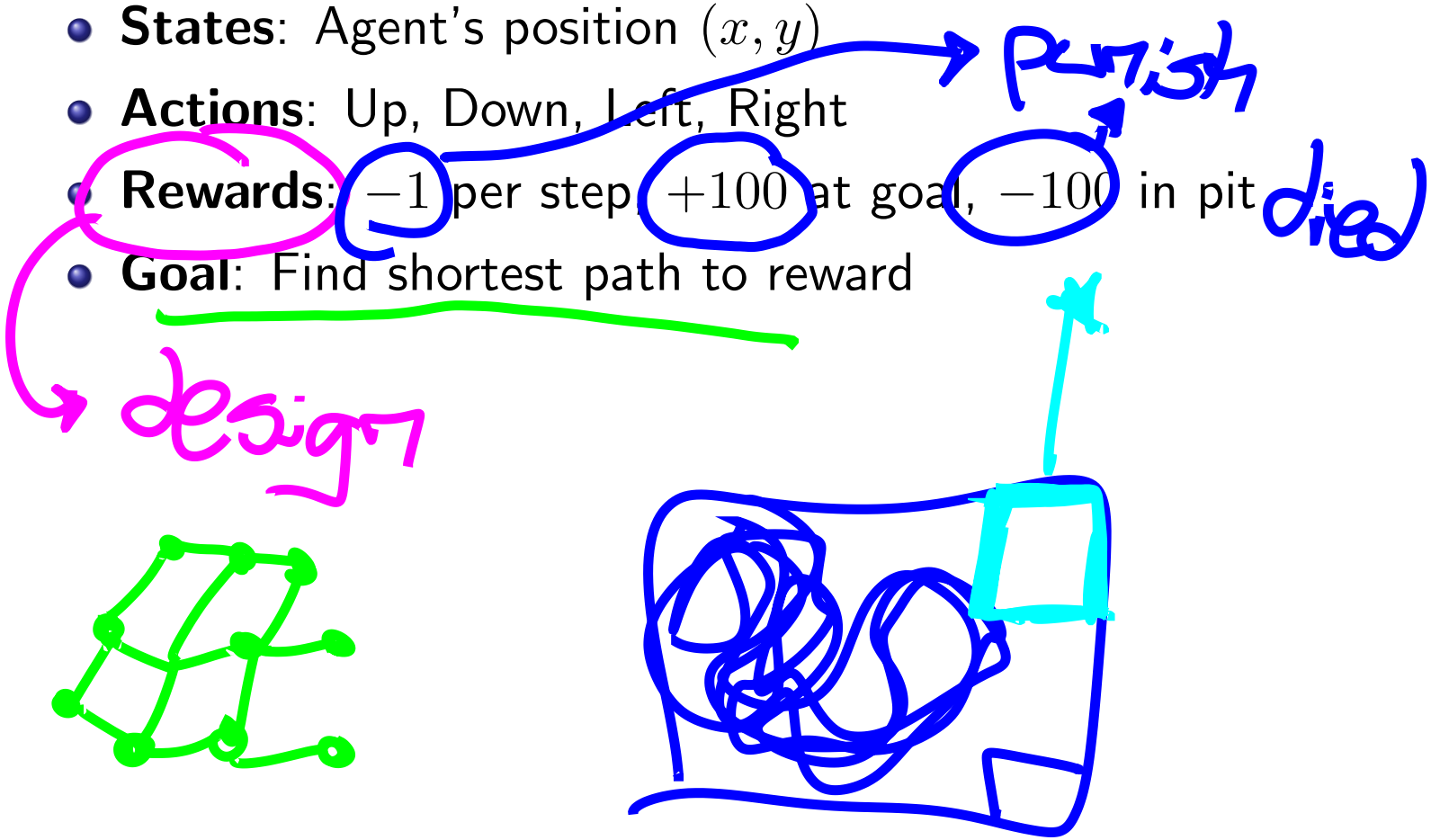






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Q-Learning Algorithm I

Definition

Q-Learning is a **model-free** reinforcement learning algorithm that learns the optimal action-value function $Q^*(s, a)$ directly from interactions with the environment.

Policy optimization

$\max \mathbb{E}[\pi(a|s)]$





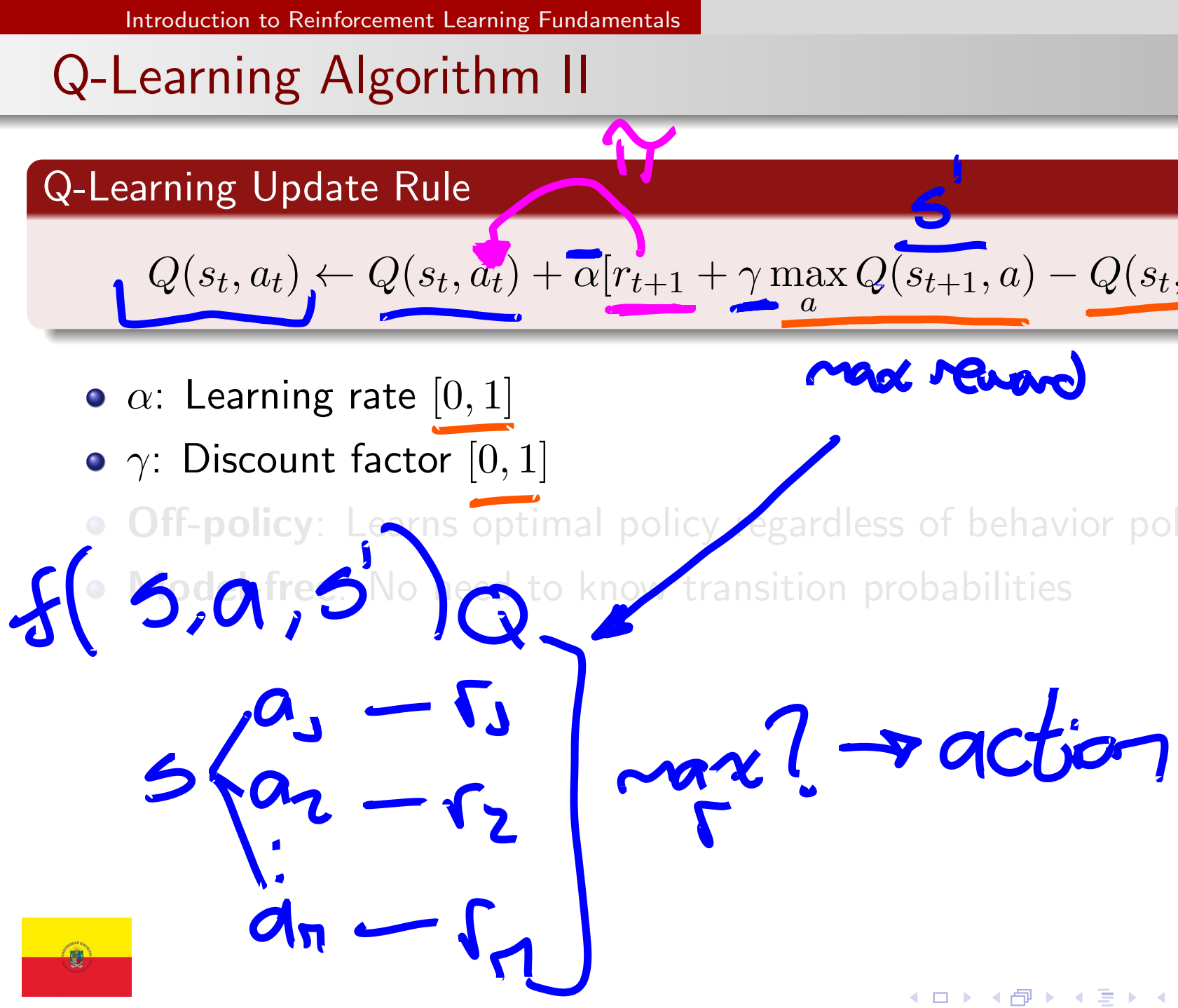
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Q-Learning Algorithm II

Q-Learning Update Rule

$$Q(s_t, a_t) \leftarrow Q(s_t, a_t) + \alpha[r_{t+1} + \gamma \max_a Q(s_{t+1}, a) - Q(s_t, a_t)]$$

- α: Learning rate $[0, 1]$
- γ: Discount factor $[0, 1]$
- **Off-policy**: Learns optimal policy regardless of behavior policy
- **Model-free**: No need to know transition probabilities



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Bellman Equation for Q-Values

Bellman Optimality Equation

$$Q^*(s,a) = E[r + \gamma \max_{a'} Q^*(s',a') | s,a]$$

s' → 1-step

2-steps forward





Bellman Equation for Q-Values

Bellman Optimality Equation

$$Q^*(s,a) = E[r + \gamma \max_{a'} Q^*(s',a')|s,a]$$

- Q-Learning approximates this equation through temporal difference learning
- The TD error: $\delta = r + \gamma \max_a Q(s',a) - Q(s,a)$
- Converges to optimal Q-function under certain conditions





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classic rule





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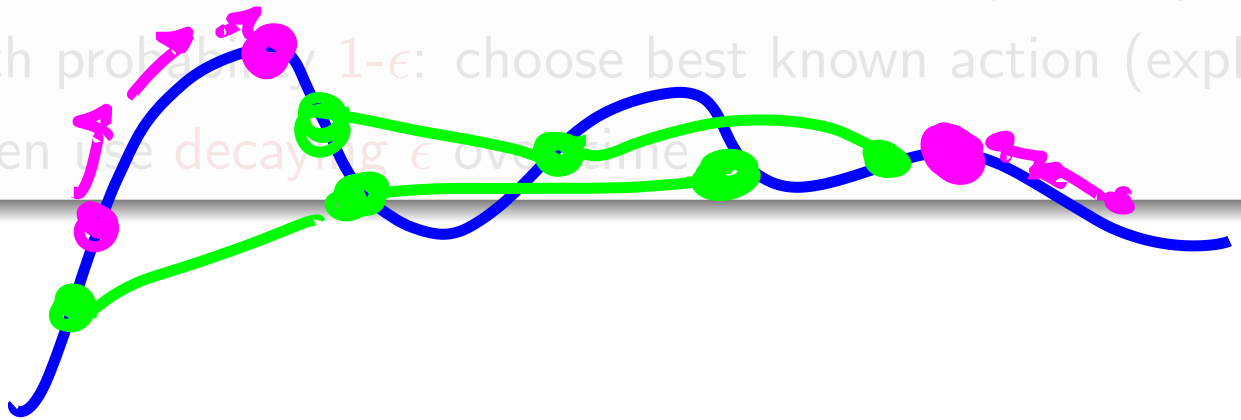
Exploration vs. Exploitation

The Exploration-Exploitation Dilemma

Should the agent choose the best known action (exploit) or try something new (explore)?

ϵ-Greedy Strategy

- With probability ϵ: choose random action (explore)
- With probability 1-ϵ: choose best known action (exploit)
- Often use decaying ϵ over time



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Practical Example: Q-Learning in Grid World

- Initialize $Q(s, a)$ arbitrarily (e.g., all zeros)
- For each episode:
  - Initialize state s
  - Repeat until episode ends:
    - Choose action a using ϵ-greedy policy
    - Take action a, observe reward r and new state s'
    - Update Q-value: $Q(s, a) \leftarrow Q(s, a) + \alpha[r + \gamma \max_a Q(s', a) - Q(s, a)]$
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np.zeros





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how to learn
- no data
- experience
- policy, epsilon-greedy, ...





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SARSA Algorithm

SARSA Update Rule

$$Q(s_t, a_t) \leftarrow Q(s_t, a_t) + \alpha[r_{t+1} + \gamma Q(s_{t+1}, a_{t+1}) - Q(s_t, a_t)]$$

- **On-policy**: Updates based on the actual policy being followed
- **SARSA**: State-Action-Reward-State-Action sequence
- More conservative than Q-Learning
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↳ does not mean "the Fast"





On-Policy vs. Off-Policy Learning

On-Policy (SARSA):

- Learns about policy currently following
- More conservative
- Accounts for exploration in updates
- Safer in risky environments

Off-Policy (Q-Learning):

- Learns about optimal policy
- More aggressive
- Ignores exploration in updates
- Faster convergence

exploration ↑





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SARSA Algorithm Mechanics

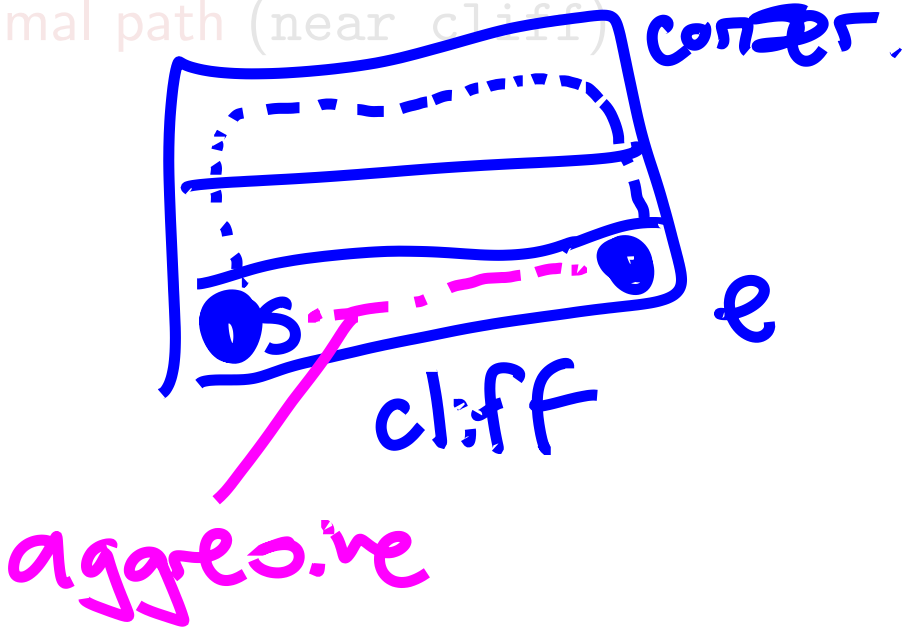
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    - Update state and action: $s \leftarrow s'$, $a \leftarrow a'$





Practical Example: Cliff Walking Problem

- **Environment**: Agent walks along a cliff edge
- **Cliff**: Large negative reward (-100)
- **Goal**: Reach the end safely
- **SARSA**: Takes safer path (away from cliff)
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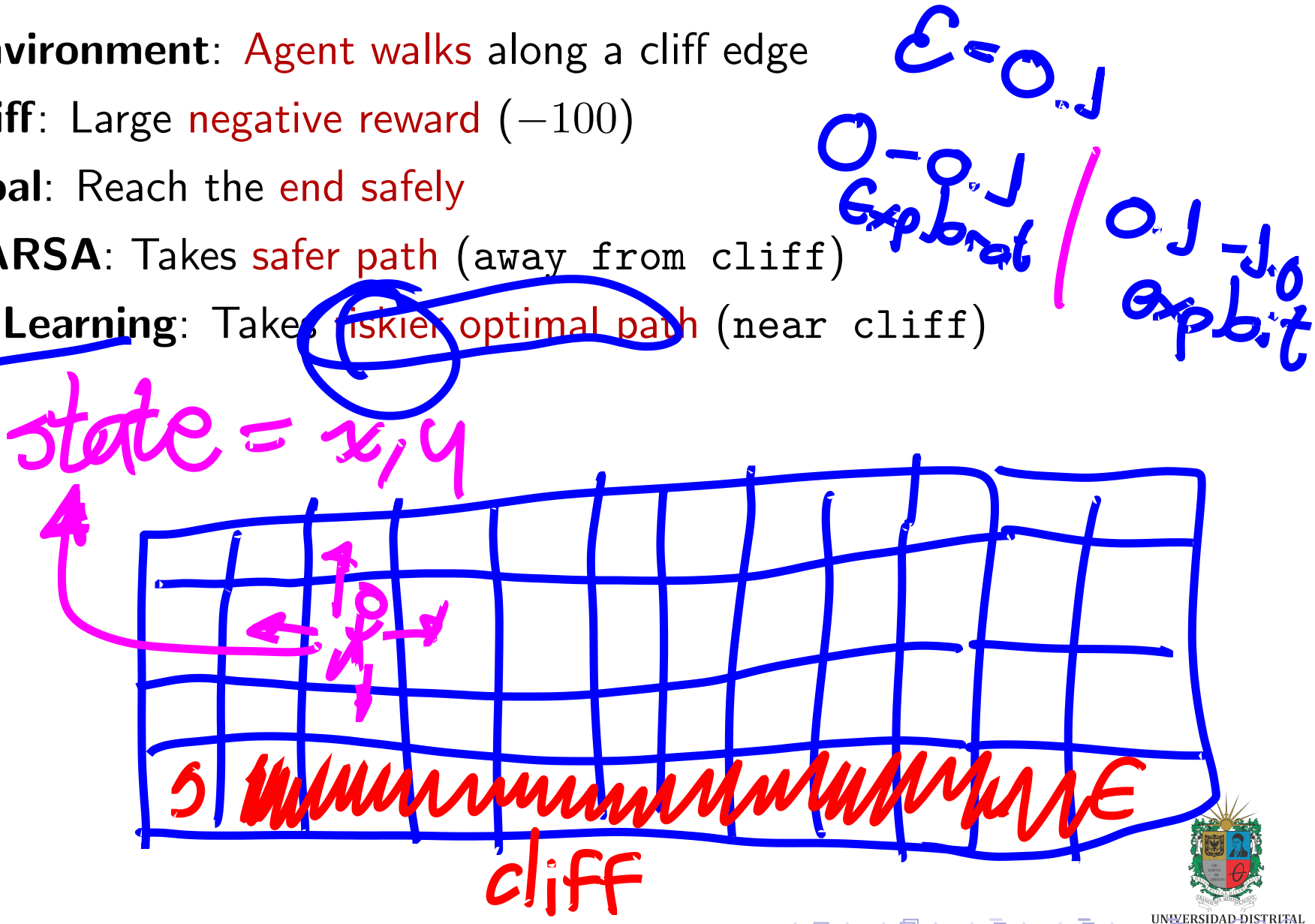




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Function Approximation in RL

The Problem

- Large or continuous state spaces
- Cannot store Q-values for every state-action pair
- Need to generalize from seen to unseen states

Solution: Function Approximation

Use neural networks to approximate: $Q(s, a) \approx Q(s, a; \theta)$





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Deep Q Network (DQN) Architecture

Key Components

- **Deep Neural Network**: Approximates Q-function
- **Experience Replay**: Stores and samples past experiences
- **Target Network**: Stable Q-targets for training
- **Fixed Q-Targets**: Reduces correlation in updates

Loss Function

$$L(\theta) = E[(r + \gamma \max_{a'} Q(s', a'; \theta^-) - Q(s, a; \theta))^2]$$



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Experience Replay Mechanism

- **Store**: Experiences (s, a, r, s') in replay buffer
- **Sample**: Random mini-batch for training
- **Benefits**:
  - Breaks temporal correlations
  - Improves data efficiency
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subset < actions states





DQN for Atari Breakout: Practical Example

Atari Breakout Implementation

- **Input**: Raw pixels $(210 \times 160 \times 3)$ $\rightarrow$ preprocessed $(84 \times 84 \times 4)$
- **Network**: CNN with 3 conv layers $+$ 2 dense layers
- **Actions**: 4 discrete actions (NOOP, FIRE, RIGHT, LEFT)

images

video

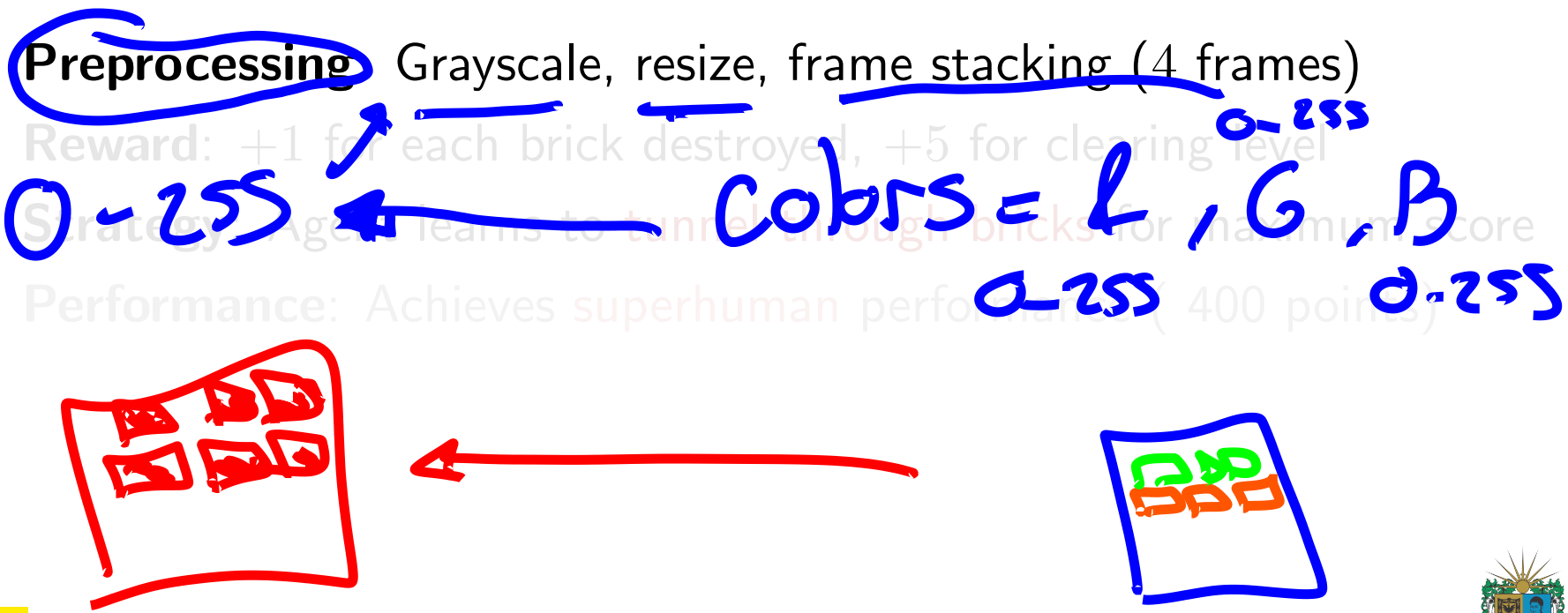




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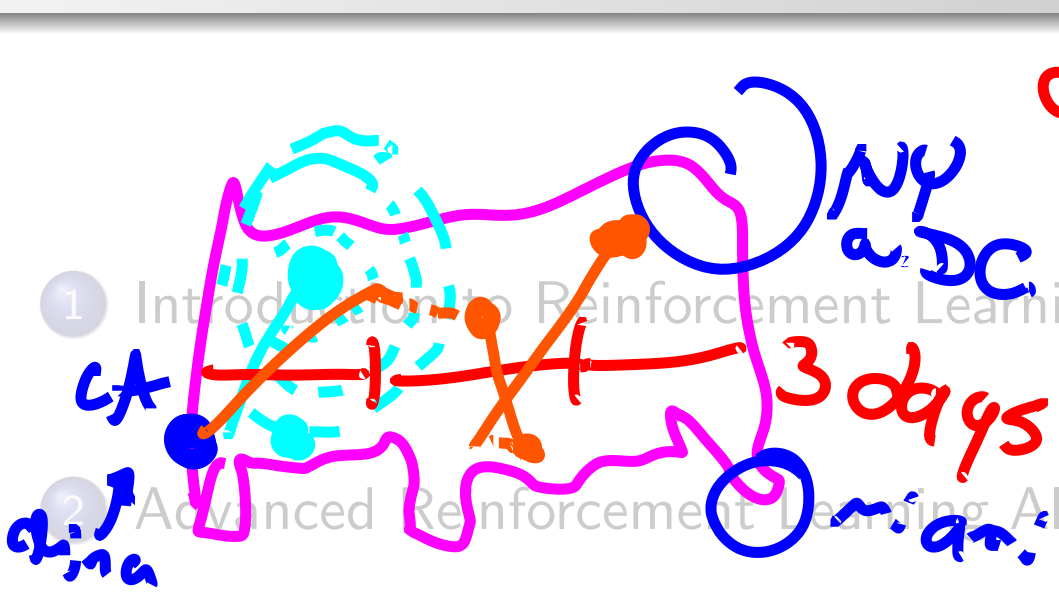




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day / max 11 hours
600 miles
3 weeks
chain-of-loads strategy
LA - Houst / ... / Austin - New Orleans / ... / NY - Miami / ...
variables (vol)
speed
graph ⇒ forecasting
(1 day | 1-7 future)
RL DQN sunday

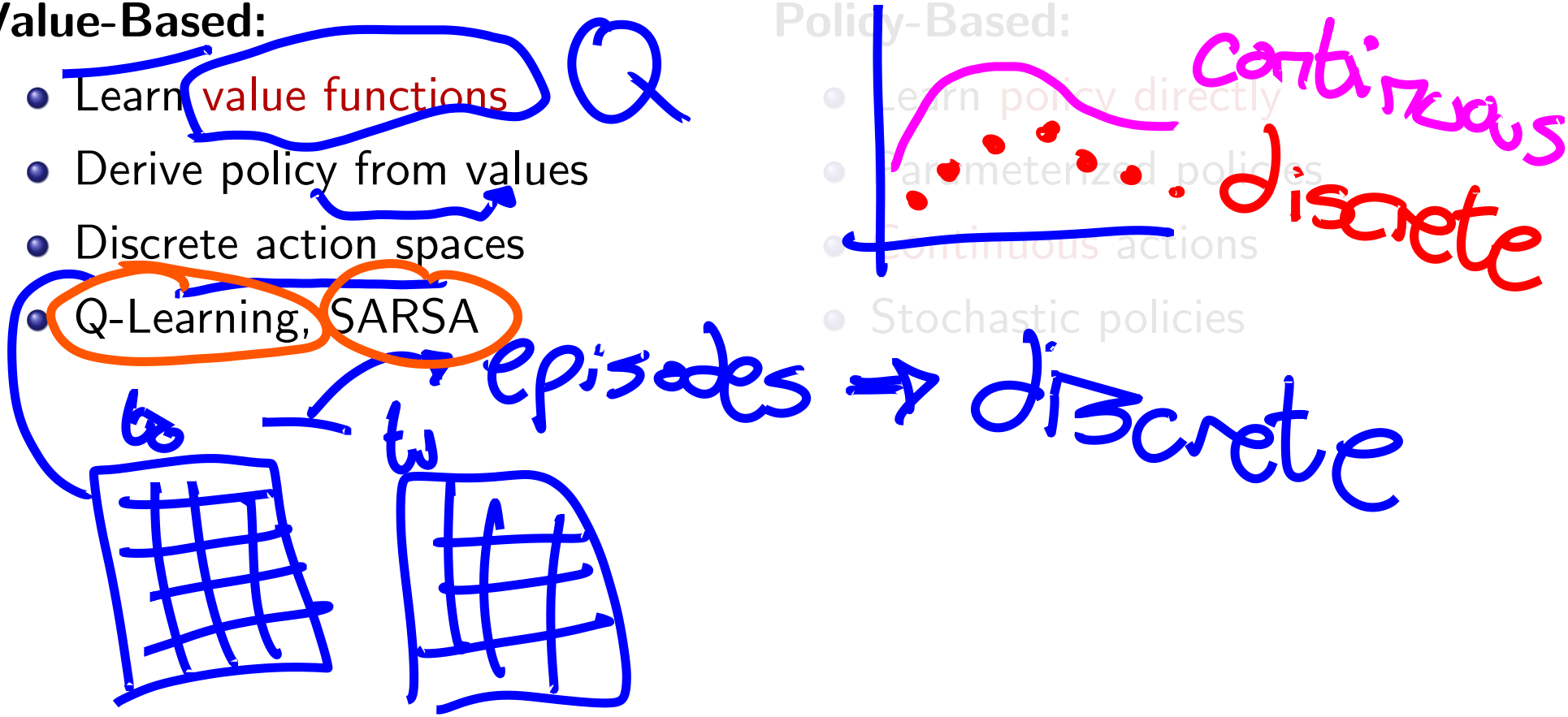
Policy-Based vs. Value-Based Methods

Value-Based:

- Learn value functions
- Derive policy from values
- Discrete action spaces
- Q-Learning, SARSA

Policy-Based:

- Learn policy directly
- Parameterized policies
- Continuous actions
- Stochastic policies







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no reward

Policy-Based:

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random + probabilities

robot arm



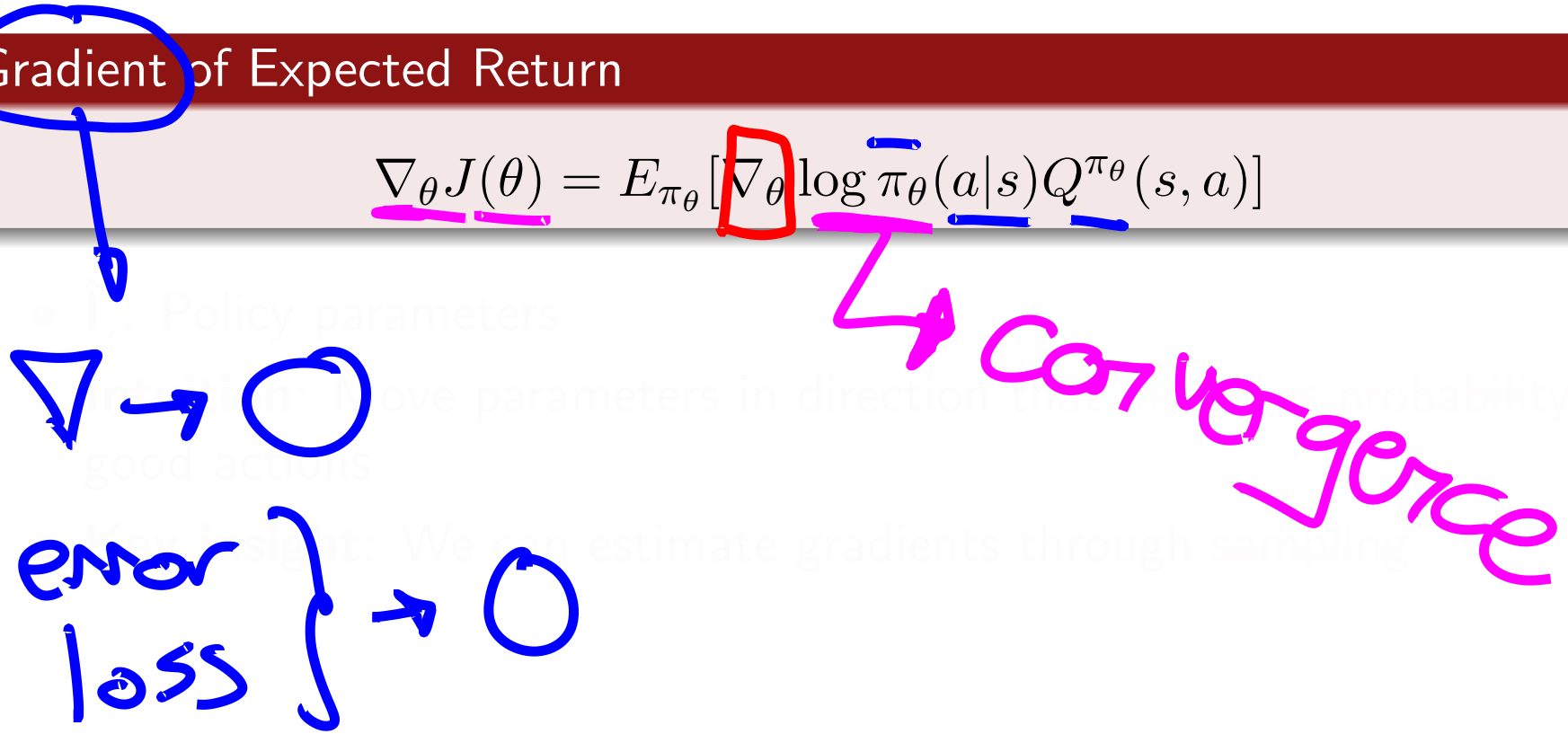


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Policy Gradient Theorem

Gradient of Expected Return

$$\nabla_\theta J(\theta) = E_{\pi_\theta}[\nabla_\theta \log \pi_\theta(a|s) Q^{\pi_\theta}(s,a)]$$







Policy Gradient Theorem

Gradient of Expected Return

$$\nabla_\theta J(\theta) = E_{\pi_\theta}[\nabla_\theta \log \pi_\theta(a|s) Q^{\pi_\theta}(s,a)]$$

- $\hat{\mathbf{I}}_{,}$: Policy parameters
- **Intuition**: Move parameters in direction that increases probability of good actions maximize reward
- **Key insight**: We can estimate gradients through sampling





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REINFORCE Algorithm

REINFORCE Update

$$\theta \leftarrow \theta + \alpha \nabla_\theta \log \pi_\theta(a_t|s_t) G_t$$

- Uses Monte Carlo return G_t
- High variance but unbiased
- Often use baseline to reduce variance
- $\theta \leftarrow \theta + \alpha \nabla_\theta \log \pi_\theta(a_t|s_t)(G_t - b(s_t))$

random experiments





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Actor-Critic Architecture

Two Components

- **Actor**: Policy $\pi_\theta(a|s)$ — chooses actions
- **Critic**: Value function $V_\phi(s)$ — evaluates actions

Benefits

- Lower variance than REINFORCE
- Online learning (no need to wait for episode end)
- Uses TD error: $\delta_t = r_{t+1} + \gamma V(s_{t+1}) - V(s_t)$





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temporal difference





Proximal Policy Optimization (PPO) Motivation

Problems with Basic Policy Gradients

- Large policy updates can be destructive
- Hard to choose appropriate step size
- Poor sample efficiency

PPO Solution

Constrain policy updates to stay in a trust region around current policy





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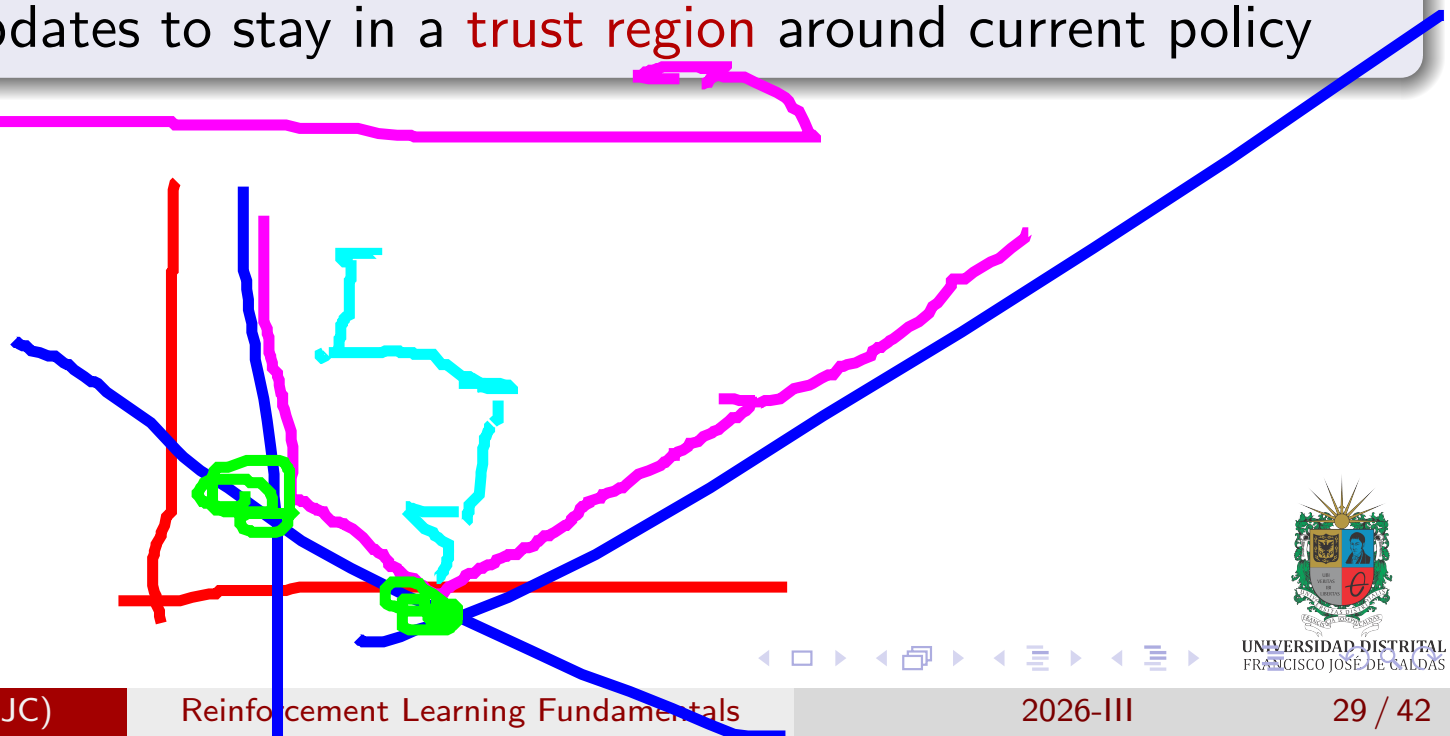
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PPO Clipped Objective

Clipped Surrogate Objective

$$L^{CLIP}(\theta) = E[\min(r_t(\theta)\hat{A}_t, \text{clip}(r_t(\theta), 1-\epsilon, 1+\epsilon)\hat{A}_t)]$$

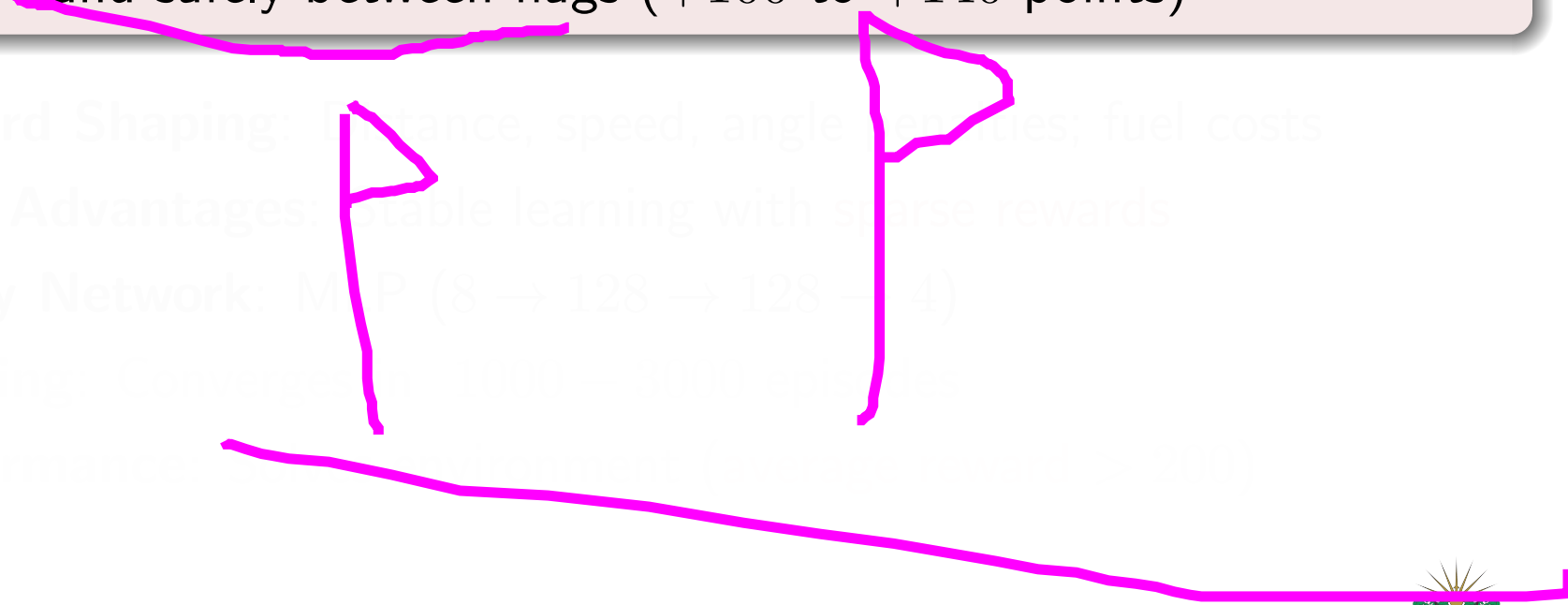
- $r_t(\theta) = \frac{\pi_\theta(a_t|s_t)}{\pi_{\theta_{old}}(a_t|s_t)}$ (probability ratio)
- $\hat{A}_t$ is advantage estimate
- Clips ratio to $[1-\epsilon, 1+\epsilon]$
- Prevents destructively large policy updates



Practical Example: PPO on LunarLander-v2

LunarLander-v2 Environment

- **State**: Position, velocity, angle, angular velocity, leg contact (8D continuous)
- **Actions**: 4 discrete actions (NOOP, LEFT, MAIN, RIGHT)
- **Goal**: Land safely between flags (+100 to +140 points)



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- **Reward Shaping**: Distance, speed, angle penalties; fuel costs
- **PPO Advantages**: Stable learning with sparse rewards
- **Policy Network**: MLP ($8 \to 128 \to 128 \to 4$)
- **Training**: Converges in $1000 - 3000$ episodes
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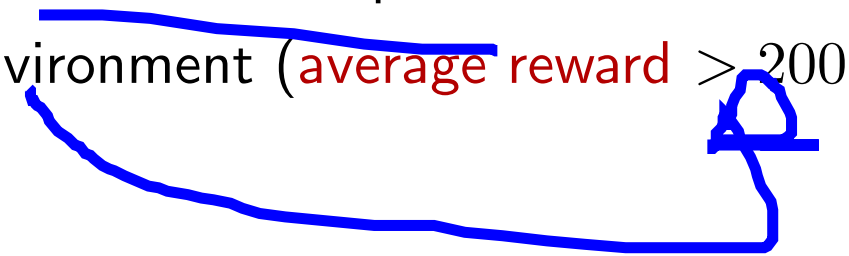
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Outline

1 Introduction to Reinforcement Learning Fundamentals

2 Advanced Reinforcement Learning Algorithms

3 Policy Optimization Methods

4 Advanced Policy Methods & Multi-Agent RL





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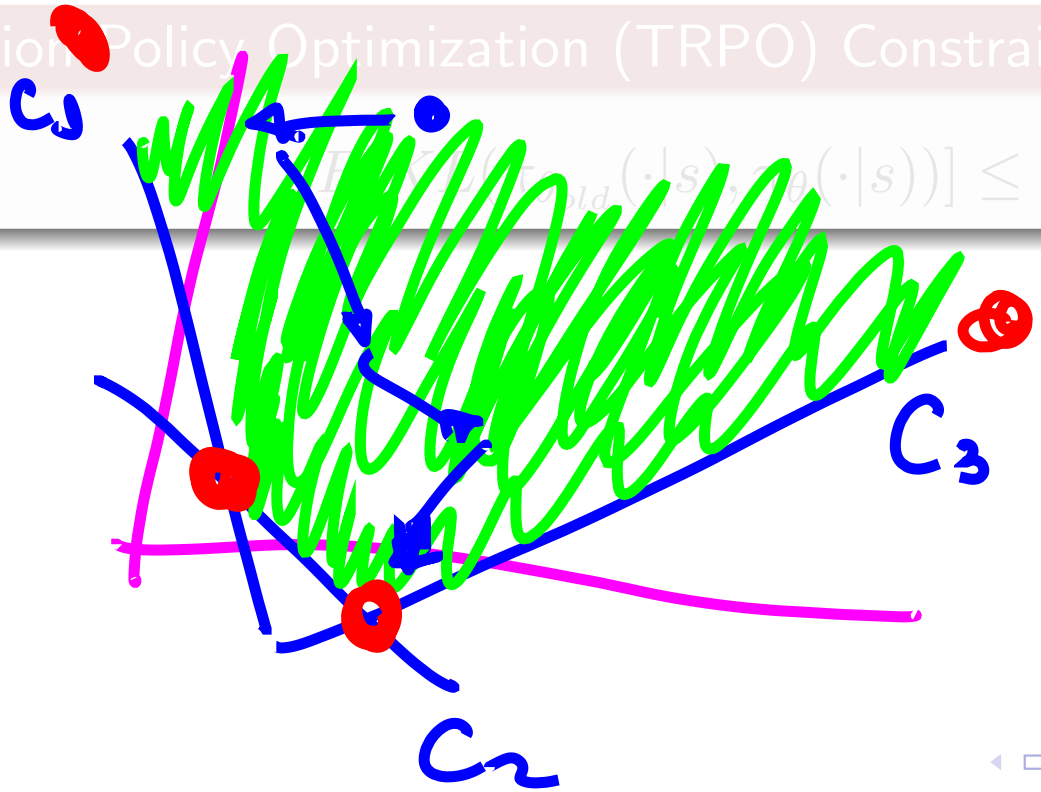
Trust Region Concept

Trust Region Optimization

- Optimize within a trusted region of current policy
- Ensures monotonic improvement
- Prevents policy collapse

Trust Region Policy Optimization (TRPO) Constraint

$$D_{KL}(\pi_{\theta_{old}}(\cdot|s), \pi_\theta(\cdot|s))] \leq \delta$$







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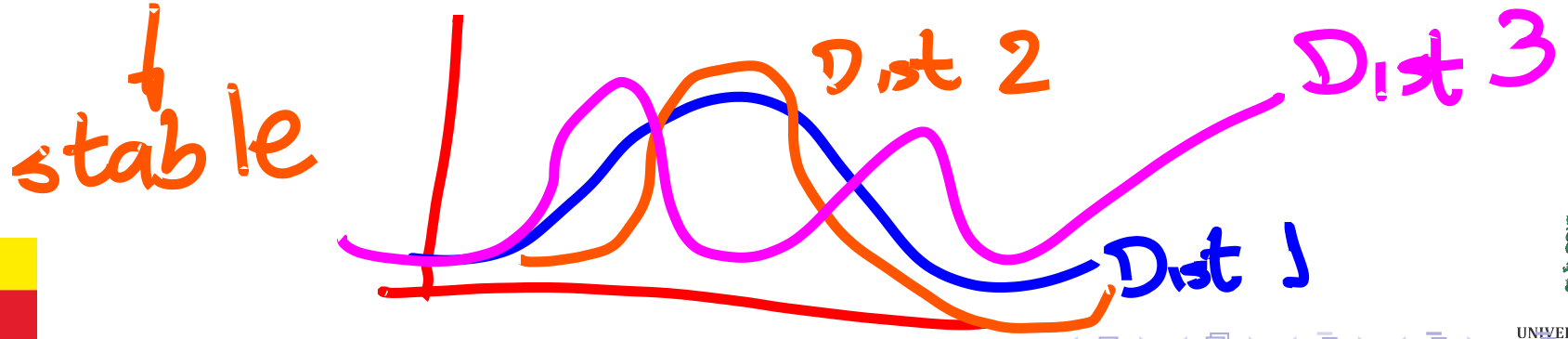
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Divergence Kullback - Leibler



TRPO Mathematical Formulation

Constrained Optimization Problem

$$\text{maximize} \quad L(\theta) \tag{1}$$

$$\text{subject to} \quad \bar{D}_{KL}(\theta_{old}, \theta) \leq \delta \tag{2}$$

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Constrained Optimization Problem

$$\text{maximize} \quad L(\theta) \tag{1}$$

$$\text{subject to} \quad \bar{D}_{KL}(\theta_{old}, \theta) \leq \delta \tag{2}$$

- Solved using conjugate gradient method
- More principled than PPO but computationally expensive
- Guarantees monotonic improvement

(x_1, y_1) $\nabla \Rightarrow (x_2, y_2)$

$KL\left((x_1, y_1), (x_2, y_2)\right) < \delta$

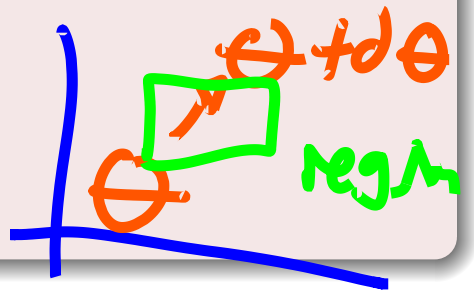




Natural Policy Gradients

Natural Policy Gradient

- Uses Fisher information matrix to scale gradients
- Accounts for geometry of policy space
- Update: $\theta \leftarrow \theta + \alpha F^{-1} \nabla_\theta J(\theta)$



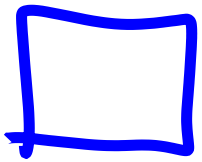
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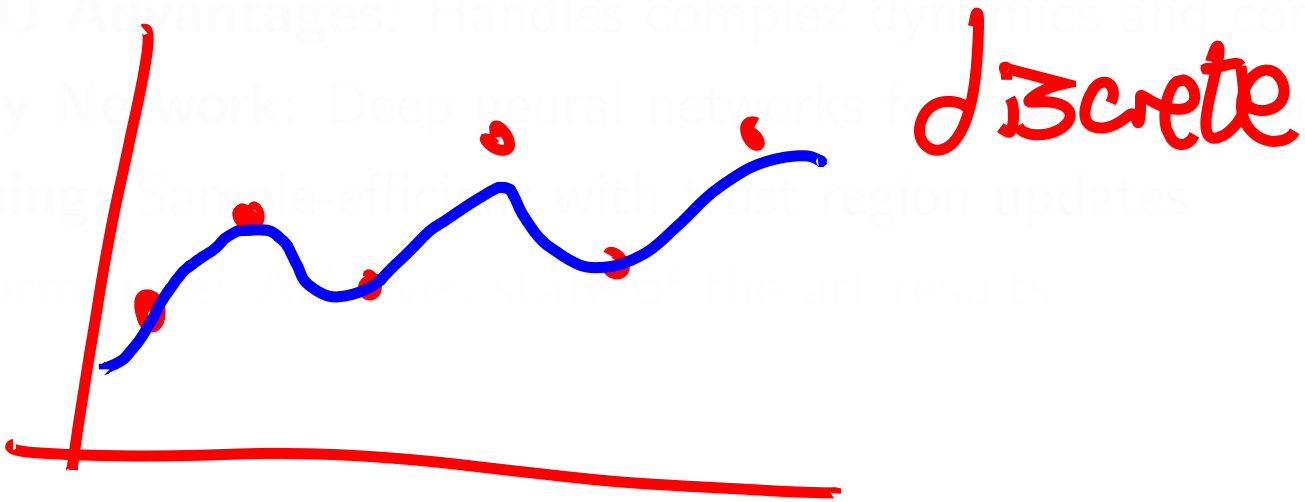
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Practical Example: TRPO in Complex Continuous Control

Complex Continuous Control Tasks

- High-dimensional state and action spaces
- Requires precise control and coordination
- Examples: *robotic manipulation*, *locomotion*



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rewards





Multi-Agent Environments

Challenges

- Non-stationary environments
- Other agents are learning simultaneously
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- **Competitive**: Zero-sum games
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soccer team



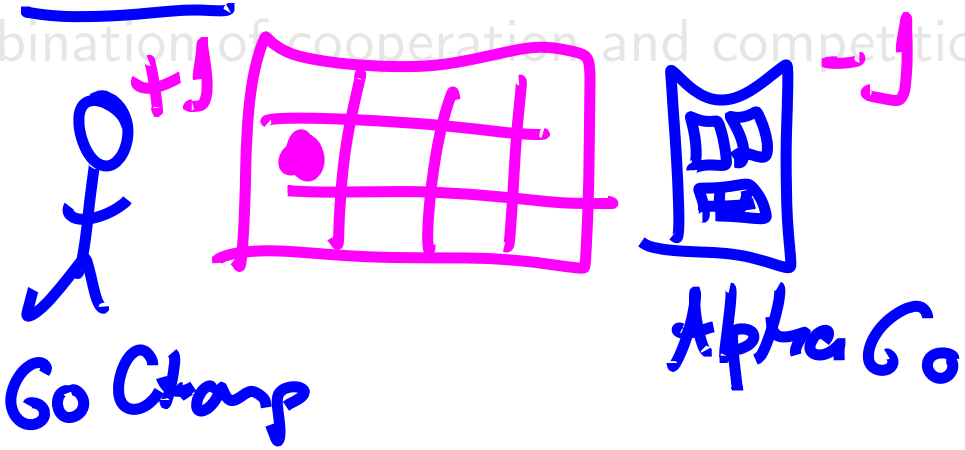


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Nash Equilibrium in RL

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A strategy profile where no agent can improve by unilaterally changing their strategy.

- Difficult to compute in practice
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- Alternative: Find correlated equilibria





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Centralized Training, Decentralized Execution

CTDE Paradigm

- **Training**: Use global information and centralized critic
- **Execution**: Each agent acts with only local observations
- Addresses partial observability
- Enables coordination during training
- Maintains decentralized execution
- Examples: `MADDPG`, `COMA`, `QMIX`





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Communication in Multi-Agent Systems

Communication Protocols

- **Explicit**: Agents exchange messages
- **Implicit**: Agents infer others' intentions from actions

- Communication can enhance coordination and performance
- Challenges: Bandwidth constraints, noise, security
- Research area: Learning communication protocols end-to-end





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Thanks!

Questions?



Repo: *https://github.com/EngAndres/ud-public/tree/main/courses/reinforcement-learning*





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